Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on E. E. Cummings's "my sweet old etcetera"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used by the contestant in a discussion of these poems include

allusion,
ambiguity,
cliché,
connotation,
denotation,
double entendre,
diction,
free verse,
irony,
internal rhyme,
parenthesis,
satire,
setting,
syntax,
theme,
tone, and
white space.

The contestant should recognize a continuum that begins with aunt lucy's programmed naïveté and continues through to the persona's self(?)-remove, through fantasy, from the reality of war. The traditional attitudes toward war, as represented in the persona's references to his immediate family, are handled as cliché misunderstandings of the deep horror of war: knitting socks and earwarmers. His parents' seemingly casual acceptance of the likelihood of his death might be recognized as an embedded allusion to Owen's "Dulce et Decorum Est." The young writer might sense satire at work.

What might well be a letter home directly references the women in the persona's life (perhaps in contrast to the woman to whom he is speaking/writing) and conclusively points to an irony, one that Aeschylus played with so long ago in *Lysistrata:* women are expected to bear and nurture children only to have them die in war. The women of his family—ready to defend the rationale for war, handcraft creature comforts, and recognize the potential for his dying bravely (thus honorably)—are apparently oblivious to the psychological/emotional/physical need for the essentiality of woman as life-giver and comforter and source of beauty against the backdrop of, among all else, war.